relatively more relaxed). *'Kya feedback hai?'* he asked like a good politician. I confessed that his lecture had been most impressive and that he deserved a nine on ten. *'Kyon, dus nahi doge kya!'* he exclaimed. My response was, *'Sir, dus deta agar aap Kuriensaab ka bhi naam lete!'* (I would have given you a ten if you had mentioned Dr Kurien's name!)

Modi's supporters, though, had no such quibbles. A hit formula had been found—Modi speaking on governance-related issues to a captive audience, with millions watching on television. A pattern had been set which would transform Modi in the weeks and months ahead from just another chief minister into a national leader the country could relate to. In school in Vadnagar, Modi had been very fond of theatre; he loved the stage and had acted in several plays in the village. Now, in his adult life, the past training would serve him well. This was now his moment to shine as a solo performer in front of a national audience. At a time when the prime minister had slipped into a seemingly irreversible silent mode and Rahul was still a hesitant public speaker, Modi filled a vacuum in the public discourse. His skill as a natural orator made him a star attraction for an audience hankering for effective communication.

The aim was to establish Modi not just as a pan-Indian leader but, very importantly, as an urban hero. In the 2009 elections, the BJP had won just fifty of the 201 urban/semi-urban seats in the country. Team Modi's internal poll had shown that their leader was gaining strong traction in urban areas, except among the urban poor and women in the twenty-eight to thirty-five age group (young women reportedly found Modi's style 'abrasive'). 'If we had to win the 2014 elections, we knew we had to sweep urban India, which is why Modiji's initial focus was on the cities,' one of his aides told me later.

Between February and July 2013, Modi addressed several select gatherings in the town hall format that showcased him not just as a politician but as a trailblazer who had evolved, or rather reinvented himself, from demagogue to statesman, from divisive figure to governance guru, from a Hindu identity politician to a problem-solving 'ideas' man—the kind who would appeal to an increasingly urbanizing society.